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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Measles outbreak worst in decades

Experts fearing a rebound across the US 25 years after nation shut door on disease

By Teddy Rosenbluth and Jonathan Corum
The New York Times

There have now been more measles cases in 2025 than in any other year since the contagious virus was declared eliminated in the United States in 2000, according to new data released Wednesday by the federal Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

The grim milestone represents an alarming setback for the country's public health and heightens concerns that if childhood vaccination rates do not improve, deadly outbreaks of measles — once considered a disease of the past — will become the new normal.

Experts fear that with no clear end to the spread in sight, the country is barreling toward another turning point: losing elimination status, a designation given to countries that have not had continuous spread of measles for more than a year.

"It's a huge red flag for the direction in which we're going," said Dr. William Moss, an epidemiologist at the Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health who has studied measles for more than 25 years.

Most of the cases this year have been tied to the Southwest outbreak — the largest single outbreak since 2000 — which began in January in a Mennonite community in West Texas and has since jumped to New Mexico and Oklahoma.

But cases have also popped up in 38 states, which experts say represents a concerning vulnerability to diseases of the past. Because of the contagiousness of the virus, researchers often think of measles as the proverbial canary in a coal

Turn to Measles, Page 9

Judge rules ex-alderman unfit for trial

Austin's worsening health likely ends corruption case

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A federal judge on Wednesday ruled that former Chicago Ald. Carrie Austin is medically unfit to stand trial on corruption charges, likely ending a case that first came to light when federal agents raided her South Side office more than six years ago.

In his 19-page ruling, U.S. District Judge John Kness wrote that although the "issue is close," Austin's chronic and worsening medical conditions, which include chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, heart ailments and cancer, make the prospect of a jury trial "an unacceptable risk to her health."

"In addition, (Austin's) present condition, which is unlikely to improve, is compromised such that her ability to participate in trial — not only in the courtroom, but also in necessary trial preparation and conferences with her counsel — would be materially impeded," the judge wrote.

Kness also acknowledged his decision "means that, barring a material improvement in her health, she may indeed never face the prospect of a guilty verdict," but

Turn to Austin, Page 5

‘That was not her’

Family left broken after a mother with allegedly deteriorating mental health is accused of killing her 4-year-old son in Logan Square during emotional collapse

By Laura Rodríguez Presa | Chicago Tribune

Wendy Tolbert deeply loved her three children and dedicated her life to them, with dreams for their future, said her ex-husband, Dion Wallace, the father of the children.

"I loved her. I still do. And I know she loved them. ... I know she loved him," Wallace, 50, told the Tribune, struggling to continue the interview.

Wallace was talking about his 4-year-old son, Jordan Wallace, whom, according to prosecutors, Tolbert stabbed more than 36 times, killing him on Independence Day morning. The mother also stabbed her two older children before setting their Logan Square home on fire, according to Chicago police.

The mother attacked her children because she believed they were "possessed by the

devil," according to Cook County prosecutors.

For Wallace, the surviving children and the rest of their family, the pain is still raw, the grief is strong and the reality difficult to comprehend. Tolbert, he said, had never been abusive toward the children despite dealing with perhaps a deteriorating mental condition.

"That was not her," Wallace said. Though he has not spoken to Tolbert, as he arranges the funeral for his 4-year-old, he prays for her because he knows, he said, that she is not OK.

"It hurts my heart that not only is my son gone, but his mom destroyed herself in the making," Wallace said. "And then I got these other two children that (are) traumatized. If something or whatever they (prosecutors) do to Wendy, it is going to be another painful situation."

Turn to Stabbing, Page 4

Above: Dion Wallace and his 10-year-old son stand outside a relative's home in Round Lake on Wednesday. Prosecutors say the boy's mother, Wendy Tolbert, stabbed him with a knife on the arm, fatally stabbed his brother, 4, and critically injured their stepsister, 13, before setting their apartment on fire in the 3600 block of West Palmer Street on July 4 in Chicago.
JOHN J. KIM/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

These rodents cut their teeth on the streets of Chicago

Field Museum study shows impact of city environment

By Lily Carey
Chicago Tribune

Three stories above the Field Museum's exhibits, rows and rows of taxidermied chipmunks filled a tray in the museum's mammal archives. Pointing to two of the oldest critters, mammalogist Stephanie Smith picked up the pair of chipmunks off the tray, balancing them in the palm of her hand.

"The oldest ones we have are from 1891, and these were collected in Jackson Park over 100 years ago," Smith said, pointing to the two chipmunks. "You can see how good-looking they both look, and that's the beauty of this collection. We preserve this material to last, generation to generation."

In many ways, these well-preserved chipmunks mirror those that Chicagoans might see scurrying down alleyways or



Voles are on display at the Field Museum as part of a new study on how Chicago's rodents are adapting to urban living. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

hopping around in parks today, with their distinctive white stripes and bushy tails.

But according to a new study by Field Museum researchers, Chicago's modern-day rodents have evolved to look quite different from what they did just a century ago — mostly because of human development.

Smith, along with assistant curator of mammals Anderson Feijó and two Field Museum interns, measured the skulls of

nearly 400 rodent specimens — collected from the 1890s to modern day — to see how their skull structure had changed over time. The study, published June 26, focused on chipmunks and voles, aiming to compare the evolution of above- and below-ground species.

They found that over time, Chicago chipmunks have overall gotten larger, but the

Turn to Rodents, Page 2

DHS agents show up at museum

Department of Homeland Security agents stoke fears by arriving unannounced at the National Museum of Puerto Rican Arts and Culture in Chicago. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Longtime alderman to step down

Ald. Walter Burnett, 27th, says he plans to step down from the City Council amid speculation that he'll be tapped to lead the Chicago Housing Authority. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

HUD complaint remains in limbo

Mayor Brandon Johnson's administration delays signing an agreement to resolve negotiations over a complaint alleging housing discrimination by the city. **Business**

